NEW CM, OLD PROBLEMS

CM BHAGWANT MANN AND AAP BROKE THE SHACKLES IN PUNJAB POLITICS. CAN THEY DO THE SAME FOR THE ECONOMY AND THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE?

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

Ever since the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) swept the assembly election in Punjab, social media has been flooded with videos of Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's past satires eviscerating politicians, bureaucrats and the police. The comedian-turned-politician is a master of the art of political satire; indeed, since 2014, Mann's wit-laced oratory has created its own niche even in the Lok Sabha. But now that he is chief minister, the shoe is on the other foot. The burdens of running a government are upon him and, for once, he will be the target of satire and much more.

On March 16, Mann took oath as chief minister at the native village of freedom fighter Bhagat Singh, Khatkhat Kalan in SBS Nagar. Politically, AAP is in a dilemma over the appointment of deputy CMs, apparently the reason for the delay in cabinet formation. Mann is apparently not keen on having deputies, whereas AAP sources in Punjab say that there have been discussions to have three deputies, one each from the OBC Sikh, Dalit and upper caste Hindu communities. The Punjab cabinet can have a maximum of 17 ministers.

Mann is aware of the huge challenges ahead, commenting after the victory that his legislators would have to work "counting the days and not months or years" to stay ahead. The biggest challenge, of course, is the depleting finances of the state. The revenue receipt targets for this fiscal is Rs 95,257 crore but, for several years now, Punjab has had a bad habit of falling short by a massive 15-20 per cent. The state has already reported a cumulative debt of Rs 2.82 lakh crore, an increase of Rs 1 lakh crore in the past five years. To add to



PRABHJOT GILL